Diaspore

△ **Emerald-cut** diaspore gemstone

While its scientific name comes from the Greek word *diaspora*, meaning "scattering", and refers to the way diaspore crackles under high heat, this gem was marketed under the trade name Zultanite, which is more suggestive of its pleochroic (colour-changing) beauty (the name was later replaced by Czarite). Diaspore displays light green tints in sunlight and raspberry purplish pinks in candlelight, and it gleams a champagne colour under indoor lighting. In mixed lighting, variations on all of these colours can occur.

Specification

Chemical name Hydrous aluminium oxide | **Formula** AlO(OH) | **Colours** White, yellow, lilac, pink | **Structure** Orthorhombic | **Hardness** 6.5–7 | **SG** 3.3–3.4 | **RI** 1.70–1.75 | **Lustre** Vitreous | **Streak** White | **Locations** Turkey, Russia, USA

Diaspore crystals | **Rough** | In this specimen, a number of purplish diaspore crystals rest on a groundmass of emery – a granular form of corundum.

Gemmy crystal | **Rough** | This almost colourless, gemmy crystal of diaspore contains a number of striations parallel to the stone's long faces.

Crystal of diaspore | **Rough** | The material comprising this facet-grade gem crystal of diaspore exhibits some transparency, but this is barely visible beneath the many characteristic striations that have developed on its surface.

Zultanite gem | **Colour variety** | Cut in a square cushion, this superb natural gem shows typical colouring, with flashes of green, blue, red, and other hues.

Fine gem | **Cut** | The clarity and brilliance that diaspore gems can achieve are illustrated by the stunning facets and light refraction in this square, scissors-cut stone.

Brilliant-cut gem | **Cut** | This skilfully faceted diaspore gemstone features an oval, modified brilliant cut with an unusually large number of faces.

Diaspore was first described in 1801 after it was found in the Ural mountains of Russia